

Book Note System

A starter guide — read non-fiction, retain it, and be able to explain and write about it. Physical books → Supernote Manta (Book Capture template) → spaced-repetition retention loop.

Keep this nearby for your first few books. After that it's muscle memory.

The one idea behind all of it

Reading is passive recognition; retention requires active production. Every step below makes you *produce* something — a recall, an explanation, a note — instead of re-reading. If a step feels a little effortful, that's the point. Highlighting and re-reading feel productive but are weak: they create an *illusion* of knowing. The work is in the recall and the notes.

Your setup at a glance

Layer	Tool	Job
Capture + thinking	Supernote Manta + Book Capture template	Read, mark, recall, distill — by hand
Permanent notes	Slip-box notebook (or Obsidian)	One idea per note, linked, kept forever
Retention + reminders	Anki / RemNote (spaced repetition)	Tells you what to review, and when
Synthesis (optional)	NotebookLM	Quiz yourself / compare across books

Handwriting is an advantage — slower and more effortful than typing, which means better encoding. Use it.

The workflow (four phases)

1 • Before a book — 5 min, once per book

- **Inspect it first.** Skim the cover, table of contents, intro, and index to get the shape of the argument.
- **Decide why you're reading it.** Write 1–2 questions you want answered — these go in the **Guiding question(s)** box and aim your attention.

2 • While reading — one Book Capture page per chapter

- **Pencil in hand.** Underline sparingly — only what matters. Capturing everything = capturing nothing.
- In the **Notes** column, jot **why** a passage matters or how it connects — not just what it says.
- Put 2–4 **keywords** per page in the **Cues** column — these become search tags (the Manta searches handwriting).
- Don't transcribe yet. Notes here are *meant* to be messy and follow the chapter.

3 • After each chapter — the most important step, ~10 min

- 1 **Close the book.** In **Free recall**, write from memory what the chapter argued and the takeaway. This does most of the work. It feels harder than re-reading — good.
- 2 **Check** your recall against your marks; fill gaps.
- 3 **Distill 2–4 Atomic note seeds** — the ideas worth keeping, each as one short claim in your own words.
- 4 Log any **Gaps**: what you didn't understand, and — once resolved — how you closed it.

4 • Weekly — ~20–30 min

- **Convert** the week's pages to text (handwriting recognition → export) and turn atomic seeds into **permanent notes** (one idea each, fully written, linked).
- **Make/approve flashcards** from those notes, then do your **spaced-repetition reviews** (a few minutes most days).
- Monthly, or when an idea-cluster forms, **write something** from your notes. Teaching it is the deepest retention step — and your end goal.

How to fill each zone of the Book Capture page

Zone	What goes here	When
Book / Ch. / Date	Identity, so the page is findable	Start of chapter
Guiding question(s)	1–2 questions you want answered	Before reading
Cues / Keywords	2–4 search tags per page	While reading
Notes (while reading)	Raw, multi-idea, follows the chapter — <i>not</i> atomic	While reading
Free recall	From memory, book closed: argument + takeaway	After the chapter
Atomic note seeds	2–4 single ideas, your words	After the chapter
Gaps	<i>what it was / how it was closed</i>	As they arise / once resolved

The **Notes** zone is supposed to be messy and cover many ideas. The **Atomic seeds** zone is where you decompose those into separate, single ideas. Don't confuse the two.

Atomic notes — the core skill

A chapter contains **many** ideas. An atomic note holds **exactly one**. So one chapter becomes **several** atomic notes — you're *decomposing* the chapter, not summarizing it.

A note is atomic when:

- You can **title it with the idea itself** — “Retrieval beats rereading” — not a topic (“Memory”) or a location (“Chapter 3”).
- It's in **your own words**, a full sentence, standing on its own.
- You could **link it to a note from a different book** and it would still make sense.

Gut check: if describing the note needs the word “*and*,” it's probably **two** notes. Be selective — three sharp atomic notes beat a full-page summary.

Example — one chapter on “anchoring” might yield: “Anchoring: an arbitrary number drags your estimate toward it.” · “Anchoring works even when the anchor is obviously random.” · “In negotiation, the first offer sets the anchor for the range.”

The retention loop (makes it stick + reminds you)

Notes alone don't create memory — **spaced retrieval** does. Wire your seeds into a spaced-repetition app so it schedules reviews and reminds you:

- 1 Turn key permanent notes into **flashcards**. Phrase the front as a real question (“Why does retrieval beat rereading?”), not a keyword.

- 2 Use **Anki** or **RemNote** (FSRS). It shows each card right before you'd forget it.
- 3 **Review a few minutes most days.** Turn on the app's daily notification — that's your reminder.
- 4 Spacing scales with your goal: to remember for a year, reviews stretch to months apart. The app handles it; you just show up.

Pitfalls to avoid

- **Collector's fallacy.** Saving/highlighting $\neq$ knowing. The note in your own words is the asset.
- **Passive re-reading & highlighting.** Feels productive, builds little. Replace with free recall.
- **Over-tooling.** Don't perfect the system instead of using it. Two notebooks and a keyword habit is enough.
- **Summarizing instead of decomposing.** A summary is one blob; you want several atomic, linkable ideas.
- **Skipping the recall step** because it's harder than re-reading. That difficulty *is* the learning.

One-page cheat sheet

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BEFORE    inspect the book; write 1-2 guiding questions.
DURING    light marks; note WHY it matters; keywords in the cue column.
AFTER     1. close book, FREE RECALL from memory
          2. check against marks
          3. distill 2-4 ATOMIC SEEDS (one idea each, your words)
          4. log GAPS (what it was / how closed)
WEEKLY    export -> permanent notes -> flashcards -> spaced reviews
          -> (monthly) write something.

ATOMIC NOTE = one idea, titled by the idea, your words, linkable.
              If it needs "and", it's two notes.

RULE OF THUMB: produce, don't re-read. If it's a little hard, it's working.
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